

The Monster Down Below

T.S

*A boy must do unspeakable things to see his mother who is
harbouring a horrific creature, making him question: Who is
the real monster?*

The worst was the wailing.

Jakob had done a lot of bad things to see Mother. He had
led good people to their death with a smile full of lies.

He didn't like doing it, their screams made him feel
guilty.

He knew the exact moment when they saw the predator that
dragged them into its crevasse. He could hear their shrieks
when it began to feast.

After this particular banquet ended, a black tendril
appeared out of the hole in the rocky earth. It whipped out
with unnatural speed, stopping lightly before hitting the
ground. Attached to it was a woman. The furry, slug like
tendril spearing through her chest held her tightly. Yellow
barbs protruded out of it, and those thorns rotated, moving up
and down the tentacle's skin, cutting the air with speed.

"Mother." Jakob greeted her with a smile and a tight
hug.

She was pale, a frail white husk blinking in surprise at the light. There wasn't much in the dim basement. It was dusty, the wooden floor scratched and dirty. Strange lights shimmered in the corners, breaking up the darkness.

"Jakob, my boy. Oh, how I love you."

He clapped his hands excitedly.

"Thanks Mother! I have so much to tell you!" Jakob didn't have any friends. No-one to tell his stories to. He spent almost as much time trying to work out what he wanted to tell Mother as he did plotting who to lead down to her.

Who to feed ... it.

"Yes dear, you can tell me soon," Mother replied dryly.

"What I want to know is, have you been a good boy?"

Jakob straightened his back.

"Of course!"

"Excellent. Thank you for bringing that man down. He was gluttonous and fed us well."

Jakob cringed at being drawn back to the memory. The Chef had been good to him, hadn't blinked an eye when Jakob asked him to come down to the basement, saying his friends needed help.

His screams had been difficult to withstand.

Jakob had to see Mother though. Not to mention that trust was dampening in the city. It was becoming harder and harder to find people who would follow him down to the basement.

Was it because he was feeding them all to the devil down below?

"But now, my boy, you must bring the King to me. Where is he, is he coming soon?"

"Of course, Mother, but it's a long process, and the King is protected so I'm not sure..."

"No!" She screamed. Her hand flung forward, battering him in the face. He fell in pain, to get back up smartly, bowing his head.

The thorns in the tendril began moving faster.

"That's not good enough. We have been kept in the dark for too long. Our strength is gathered, now is the time to strike. You want to see me again?"

Then bring the King to me."

Jakob stared at her in horror.

He began crying, sobs loud and ugly. No sympathy was forthcoming.

Until he gurgled, "Yes Mama."

She immediately caressed him, tucking his head beneath her chin, stroking his throbbing cheek. He squirmed, not in repulsion, but to get into a more comfortable position.

"I'm so sorry sweetie. Mama has a bit of a temper on her, doesn't she? Everything will be ok. Just be a good boy, and Mama will always be there for you."

Jakob nodded.

She rubbed his back. Then then tentacle in her chest began to pulsate and vein throughout her body popped a rich blue.

"Now, Mama has to go."

"No!" Jakob squealed, an unnatural sound since his teenage voice had already broken.

"Yes, my beautiful boy. But you know how to see Mama again.

Don't you?"

Jakob wiped the tears from his face. His voice became stronger.

"Yes Mother. The King. I'll bring him to you."

The tendril receded, swinging her body in the air, before retreating into the pit.

Jakob turned to leave, when he stiffened. He felt an abnormal presence behind him.

Slowly, he turned.

Black fur took up his vision. A yellow beak drew level with his eyes, a green tongue slithered out as hot air blew not his face.

The *thing* screeched.

Jakob winced; the sound was piercing.

Once the shriek finished, the tongue spat something to the floor.

The creature dragged itself back into its hole. Following the charcoal body was a mass of tendrils sprouting out of its husk, the slippery sound sending shivers down Jakob's spine.

He bent to pick up what it had left behind. It was a golden ring, its emerald gemstone covered in black muck. The only reason he knew it was emerald was that he had seen it when it was on the Chef's finger.

He couldn't sell it, someone might identify it as the Chef's.

It would be a crime to the man's memory if Jakob threw it out.

May as well add it to the collection.

Jakob licked his lips, waiting in the shadows.

He had tried to see Mother recently. Alone. The response had been a roar at the back of the large basement and a rumble in the ground.

Translation? 'Don't come back without food.'

So, Jakob began his plan. One of the Majul brothers had a taste for younger flesh. It was information that was hard to come by, as the powerful gangster, or at least, his powerful family, did their best to squash the rumours.

A difficult feat, considering that there was more effort to stop the gossip than to curb what was causing it. Jakob didn't particularly care. He would bring good or evil to the basement.

Jakob heard footsteps trudge down the wet alley. Heavy boots sprayed water that had pooled among the uneven cobblestones. Torches were nailed on the tight brick walls to provide light that cut through the darkness.

When the steps were close, Jakob turned the corner. He saw the men and squealed, darting away when his foot conveniently got tangled up with something.

He fell with a crash. They were upon him in an instant.

"Who are you?" questioned a gruff voice. Swords had slithered out of scabbards, sharp points nestling at his throat.

"Oh please sirs. Don't hurt me!" Jakob whimpered.

There were three men in front of him. One stepped around him and moved with caution, looking around the corner where Jakob had come from.

"Clear." He yelled.

The other man then stepped to the left, to allow Vilan Majul forward.

"What have we here?" The dirty blonde man smiled. He had a lisp, the wet sound echoing out of the gap between his two front teeth.

He roughly grabbed Jakob's chin; dirty, cracked nails digging into flesh. Beady eyes stared down at the boy with eagerness, making Jakob's throat constrict with fear.

"How old are you boy?"

"I'm ten sir."

Jakob cried out as Majul slapped him.

"What do you think I'm stupid? You're almost as tall as me boy, you're not ten. What are you trying to do? Is someone paying you to lead me on?"

Majul slapped him again. The pain was nauseating.

Yet he didn't scream, didn't withdraw into himself. He had had worse beatings.

"Ok, I am sorry sir. I just thought, you might hurt me if I was older ..."

"I know you!" One of the bodyguards interrupted with a pointed finger.

"You tried stealing a piece of fruit off a stand. Almost got your fingers chopped off for an apple."

Jakob hung his head. Being subservient made it easier to hide his smile. Almost getting caught had been no accident.

"I must apologise sirs. I was starving, and I was doing it for my brother."

Majul cut him off.

"We might have to take you to the authorities boy.

How old is your brother?"

The question came out of the blue.

"He's eight sir. It's just him and me. With no parents and all, we only have each other."

"No parents?" Majul repeated with a whisper.

"No sir." Jakob put a weak smile on his face. An innocent one.

Suddenly Majul hauled Jakob up, brushing dust off his jerkin. He rustled the boy's hair.

"Oh, that's just so sweet, you taking care of your family. I'm so sorry boy. Why don't you take us to where you're staying. I'll get some hot food into your bellies, and a nice place to stay the night. Would you like that?"

Jakob looked at Majul. The man had been beating him only seconds ago. He could still feel the scratches on his chin where Majul's nails had been gripping him.

This change of tone, the big smile, the loving demeanour.

For some reason, it seemed awfully familiar.

"Really sir? You would do that for us? How would I be able to repay you?"

Majul's shadow seemed to grow, almost extinguishing the lamplight that illuminated his smile.

"I'm sure you will find a way."

Jakob returned the grin. He knew the horrors this man was imagining. It didn't give him any satisfaction later, when he heard his screams, when he saw those beady eyes widen with fear, right before the sickening crunch.

Mama's hugs and coos made him feel a little better. Not when she gave him Majul's ring and told him what to do with it.

Certainly not when he saw the black tentacle inside of her ripple with ferocity. How many more times would he have to do this?

Mama promised him that everything would change. He just had to bring the King to her.

Why was she smiling like Majul when she said that though?

It was a fine afternoon, full of heat, sun and cheer when they snatched him.

Jakob had been very happy, sitting on a stone pedestal, near the celebrating crowds as he licked his ice cream, the sticky honeycomb slathering onto his clothes and hands. It was an excellent way to avoid the horrors down below.

A couple of weeks had passed since the Majul incident. Jakob had sold the gangster's ring to a trusted broker, and after no repercussions, had managed to use the quite large sum to buy some proper food. He also bought a toy, that he made sure not to show Mother. It was a little red box, with a handle at the back that Jakob could crank. When he let it go, it would make a jingle, before a clown erupted from the box. Jakob loved it so much.

It made him less inclined to go back to see his Mother. Did he even need her? He hadn't completely ignored her, having been down a couple of times since, always with an unsuspecting and now, deceased, companion.

Each time was worse. He didn't like how Mother said that the only reason he was looking good, dressing well and eating better, was because of her plan. What had she done? *Nothing*. Just hurt him.

Although, he wouldn't have money if she hadn't eaten the Majul gangster. He did love her. She always looked out for him.

Except ... Jakob's thoughts and feelings tumbled around.

Recently, Mother had been getting angrier. Staring at him with a look that made him anxious to see her. The anxiety grew whenever he wasn't with her, it was a sickness that tickled the back of his throat. When she hugged him, kissed his cheek and told him that she loved him, it would go away.

But when she was in her one of her moods, all he could think about was that tentacle in her chest, the blades in its slimy coat whirring, the stench of the basement.

Jakob shivered in the heat. That was when the hand clamped over his face.

Instantly, Jakob bit down on the fingers covering his mouth, spinning out of the attacker's grasp to land on the

ground. He sprinted away, looking backwards to see two men in thick brown tunics yelling at him.

He should have kept his eyes forward. Jakob turned to see a black cudgel wallop him in the face. His vision quickly faded to black as he fell onto the ground.

How could this happen in broad daylight?

The Majul crest on his attacker's shoulder highlighted the man's impunity.

Jakob bared his teeth at Dagan Majul. The most powerful man in the city sat down on a seat in the dirty cell, taking off his top hat.

Goons flanked him ominously. Jakob wasn't scared. He hadn't reacted when he had woken up chained to the wall in the stinking dungeon. Hadn't said anything when jailers had come, waving tools and making threats.

Dagan was a gangster that ruled the city. The King they called him, despite the fact that there was an actual monarch that sat on a throne in the Royal Palace.

Yet that King was not who Mother wanted. She wanted power, to rule the underbelly. Jakob was here to deliver.

"First off boy. I'm sorry for the treatment you have received."

Dagan laughed at Jakob's astonishment

"Have you not seen compassion before? You must understand that you, and all children, are the future of this world. You deserve protection, which is why I forbade my men to hurt you.

Are you alright?"

Jakob watched him with suspicion, saying nothing.

"It's alright child. I won't hurt you.

At the same time, I won't let you leave this cell until you've answered some of my questions.

We managed to track down my dear brother's ring, and after a lot of chasing shadows, the trail has led to you.

I make large efforts to make the Majul family seem invincible, and now my enemies sniff blood. I need my brother back.

Would you know where he is?"

Jakob pursed his lips, looking away.

Dagan stepped up from his stool. Jakob braced himself, closing his eyes.

When no blow came, he looked up with confusion. Dagan Majul was breathing heavily, his eyes puffy as he rubbed his forehead.

"I repeat boy. I won't hurt you. No matter what you say, you ARE safe. Just please.

Help me."

Jakob spoke; the words harsh on his dry throat.

"Why would I help you find that ... monster." The tremble was not an act. Remembering Vilan Majul was not pleasant. Neither was remembering what had happened to him.

Dagan sighed.

"I know what my brother was. All of us have monsters in the family. We know that we should despise them. Yet we don't. Or at least I don't.

So, I must ask. Is he still alive?"

Jakob tried to spit. "You say children are the future.

Did you not know what your brother was doing? How could you let him?"

Dagan bowed his head.

"I know. I did my best to repair the damage. Give the victims a life. Or give other children the love and care to make up for Vilan's actions.

There is no excuse. Family, no matter what the cost, is my vice."

Jakob stared at Dagan. Was this, a good person? He might not be virtuous, but he was saying he helped people.

Jakob didn't help anyone. He just fed a monster.

Was that ... wrong?

The question caused turmoil in his chest. So he followed his instinct, what had been drilled into him by the woman who raised him. Put yourself first. No matter what.

She hadn't changed even after having a tendril stuck in her chest.

Jakob did what he knew best.

He lied.

"Vilan is alive. But he is guarded. You will need many soldiers."

"Where?" Dagan shot back.

"In a basement. I will show you."

With that, Jakob led a feast to the monster down below.

"Down there," Jakob pointed.

Men and women stood in the wooden room. Debris cluttered the ground. Dust and giant cobwebs were growing out of control in the corners of the roof, lengthening onto the walls.

Jakob had never seen any drifters using the shelter.

It seemed that those who moved from place to place could sense what was safe. And what was not. The derelict building held a stench, filling the air and clogging the nostrils.

The gangsters surrounding Jakob moved with unease, knives and blunderbusses held at the ready. Jakob strode to one corner, pulling down a cloth-like screen hanging from the ceiling.

Behind was a wooden staircase that curled downwards. The gang members looked backwards for confirmation and Dagan nodded.

Five of them began descending, loud creaks signifying their progress.

"Clear!" floated up a call.

They moved. The staircase was circular, spinning downwards in dizzying fashion, the rotting wooden frame antithetical to the strong stone walls. It was cramped and while the darkness was overpowering, no-one held a torch or lantern. They didn't need too.

Abnormal lines glowed green and red on the walls. The lines weaved in erratic directions, even flowing into symbols that were alien from any language Jakob had ever seen.

Dagan stopped and looked at Jakob.

"What is this?"

"I don't know. It's pretty though don't you think?"

Jakob touched one of the symbols. It flared golden and light poured out to show the symbol in the air as a projection, before it faded away. Dagan frowned but was interrupted before he could respond.

"Boss! We need you down here!"

The group quickly hurried down.

They entered a very large room. The roof was brown and layered with brick, wooden floor overloaded with dirt. Darkness engulfed the way forward, although the lines and symbols from the staircase continued onto the walls. The light began to pulsate brightly at irregular intervals. It smothered everyone's field of view, the transition between quick bright light and creeping darkness epileptic.

"There's nobody here, boss. Although it seems the way forward goes into the ground. There's a large hole there, almost like a cave."

"Did you find my brother?" Dagan asked. The responding shake of the head was distinguishable even in the intermittent darkness.

"What the hell is that smell?" One woman asked with fear. It had grown stronger. Every person who had entered the room had stopped for a second, paralysed. It stunk of death. There was no other way to describe it.

"Alright, begin fanning out ..." Dagan began.

"Croaaaaak," a loud sound was heard in the distance. Everyone snapped their heads around, tensing at the unknown screech.

Dagan slowly looked at Jakob. Already he knew the lie. Yet he asked the question regardless.

"Where is my brother, boy?" The words were faint. Stilted.

Jakob swallowed, tears starting to fill under his eyes.

It never got easier, bringing people down here. It didn't matter whether they were good or bad.

It was always wrong. Why was he doing this?

"It's too late now sir. I'm sorry."

A shadow loomed in the black. Big, fat tentacles shot out into the air, the sound wet and loud. They sprayed forward to land on the floor. A scream, as one smashed into the chest of

a man, pinning him to the ground. Everyone stared in horror, frozen in shock at the alien sight. Yellow and white spikes sprung out of the tendril and began *moving*. Up and down, they flew on the surface of the black skin, ripping and tearing through the body of the fallen man. His cries were abhorrent.

A couple of men grabbed axes from behind their backs to cut through the entrenched arm-like 'thing'. But it was already too late. There was nothing to save.

The man was no longer human, just a pulverised and churned up piece of meat.

A round shape rose out of the crevasse. It was furry and dark black, a ball that had multiple tendrils springing out of its bulk.

A behemoth, it elevated itself into the air, supported by its anchoring tentacles. The body rotated in inhumane fashion, a yellow beak in the middle that roared, the power of the sound almost blowing Jakob off his feet.

Some of the monster's spit splashed onto his arm.

Black sludge, it began to harden on his shoulder, restricting his movement and causing his arm to feel as heavy as lead. One man had caught a full mouthful of the stuff, and black, parasitic mould grotesquely hardened around his face.

It began to spread. The man opened his jaw to scream, and he tilted his neck; what should have been an instant movement

was excruciatingly slow until it wasn't a movement at all, the man was immortalised in the solidified gunk, his neck only partially bent at the side. Except his eyes. They kept moving; *he was still alive.*

Dagan moved his hands to the inside of his jacket and brought out two large, golden blunderbusses. Weapons of death, Dagan held them with ease, cocking the barrels with each thumb routinely.

"Alright men! Aim!"

"Enough!" A feminine cry was heard, stopping the call for fire.

The beast roared at the sky, covering the ceiling with its paralysing mud, until it moved backwards.

A withdrawal.

A woman rose down from the roof, her arms spread out like the messiah, her long black dress so ripped and torn that she was partially naked.

Levitating down, Mother stopped in front of Dagan, the black extremity inside her chest wriggling so much that green goo leaked down her pale stomach.

"The true King of our mighty city. You've finally arrived."

Dagan stared at the newcomer.

"Who the fuck are you?"

She looked around at the entourage, smiling yellow and black teeth at them.

"I'm the future. My fellow gangsters. This city. *Our city*, is quite simply, food.

The weak, the powerless, the innocent, they work themselves to death for the mighty. They throw their meaningless lives away without thought because they have hope, belief that they could be something more.

It's a fool's lie.

Worse, it's cruel. Hope is non-existent. Hope is the most brutal torture known to man.

Under my rule, knowing that you're food and nothing more, will be freedom. This is the virtuous path.

Who would like to join me?"

She patted the tendril inside of her. The barbs swirling around its skin cut her soiled flesh. Blood trickled down a clenched fist, yet she seemed not to notice.

Silence.

Then, laughter. A boisterous chuckle came out of Dagan.

"You're psychotic. No-one will join a monster."

"Are you any different? Tell me, do you really think you're good man Dagan Majul?"

He stared at her. The top hat came off his head with a gloved hand.

"I'm not a good man. But I can't be, in the monstrous world we live in. Life is harsh on the men and women beside me. On the peasants on the streets, the children, even the rich.

I must be nasty. I must kidnap, torture and kill so that my subjects don't have to. So I may protect the innocent and the unfortunate.

And not just protect them.

I feed them. Defend them. Care for them and put myself in harm's way.

Terror is a tool, but not the only one. I have loyalty.

What do you have woman?"

Mother smirked her rotten teeth.

"Protecting the innocent? The children? Is that what you did when you sat back and let you brother victimise our city's litter?"

Dagan snarled.

"You know nothing woman. Vilan's atrocities were just a symptom of what I must do to protect them all.

The many is greater than the few."

"You lie Dagan. Your virtuous path is a farce.

And it will lead you only to death. Jakob my boy. Come here darling."

Jakob took an instinctive step forward. A wave of emotions cascaded through him, and he stopped, shaking his head.

"No Mother."

The woman screamed. It was a normal cry, or as normal as what could be emitted from a human. Until it turned deeper, strangled, a sound that drowned one in the darkness.

"Boy!" Her voice echoed with power.

"Come here now!" The skin on one side of her face tore backwards as she howled, displaying white bone and a skull's eye socket.

Jakob felt the pressure of her anger.

"Yes Mama!" he whimpered, unable to reduce the pounding in his brain as he scampered over to her.

She cackled softly as the tentacle pulled her upwards to the sky.

"Time to eat my pet."

Dagan raised his weapons.

"Fire!"

What happened next was a flurry of light, sound and blood.

Guns fired. Explosions buffeted the spherical monster.

Jakob ran to a wall; it was a miracle he wasn't hit.

The creature roared its defiance, and the tendril holding Mother withdrew backwards, dragging her to safety.

The other tentacles caused some damage.

One extension swung towards a man. It slammed into him, propelling him forward until it hit a wall. The limb began to wrap around the man, tightening to such a degree that he spat up dark blood. The barbs quickly rotated around the skin of the tendril, cutting him up with such ferocity that blood sprayed like a geyser.

A different tendril speared into a man, simply going through him like he was jelly, to then curl around and exit through the back of a different, unsuspecting lad. It picked them both up into the air and the moving blades did their work until the bodies fell to the ground in quarters.

The monster continued to screech, spitting black liquid forward in attack. Many ducked away to safety. One woman was

not so lucky. She was covered head to toe in the gunk, and her movements began to slow down until she stopped altogether, body locked in a mummified pose.

The monster was a freak of nature, yet Dagan's gang weren't going down without a fight. Yellow ichor flowed from the monster's black ball-like body, lead balls from blunderbusses thudding into it. Loud explosions of lit gunpowder paired well with the smell of smoke from the flintlocks. Men and women who had fired all the pellets from their pistols drew out swords and daggers, ready to begin their butchery.

It was like a spider trying to defeat an army of ants, no matter how many fell to its flailing legs, there were just too many soldiers to replace the deceased.

That's when the basement filled with sound, as more people charged down the staircase, shouting their war cries and brandishing weapons.

Dagan was not stupid. He had hidden reinforcements.

The fight was going badly for the behemoth. It was circled by gangsters, swords flicking golden blood everywhere. So much so that some soldiers began slipping on the ichor lathering the floor.

Its tendrils began to move slower. The gangsters howled, sensing its weakness.

Jakob stood off to the side watching the madness. Soon, the creature's black bulk was blocked from view due to the amount of people hacking away at it. The monster screeched a death scream and fell to the ground lifeless, its heavy body crashing with finality.

The men and women screamed in exhilaration.

One man put his foot on top of its beak and pumped his sword in the air.

The beak opened and snapped his foot off in two.

He fell, his bloody stump adding to the river of gold. The beast's body began buzzing, and those horrific barbs only seen on its tentacles, snapped out of the flesh on its ball-like body. These thorns were pasty white and began to whirl around its skin, albeit much slower than those on its tendrils due to their larger size.

Gangsters who had celebrated too closely were the first victims, losing fingers and skin to the prickly barbs.

The monster pushed itself up with its limbs and its body began to spin, its beak moving back and forth. Everyone froze at the new action; it was too high for them to attack. That was when the beast *rolled*.

It smashed to the ground and began moving forward. Gang members in its path were crushed to death.

It rolled to the corner and around the room, people diving out of the way for dear life. Until it returned to the centre of the basement. Its new barbs stopped moving around, simply jutting out.

It let out another of its crass screeches and the barbs *shot out*.

They sprayed across the room. Missiles smashed into the unsuspecting men and woman, the white thorns embedding themselves deep in the muscle. No-one was spared.

Jakob was caught in the shoulder and left leg. He spun with the force of it, grunting as he went down.

He felt a pain in the two spots. It began to burgeon, sheering agony building with power.

Screams echoed through the basement. Everyone howled as one, the poison corrupting thought.

Jakob writhed around on the ground, madness inflicting him.

Until it just ... stopped.

He opened his eyes at the sudden release. To see Mother holding two bloody barbs that she had yanked out of his tissue.

"Get up."

Jakob merely curled into a ball. The pain might have disappeared, but the memory was just as sharp.

He was yanked upwards. Mother lifting her hand with menace.

"I'm up Mama, I'm up!" He screeched.

"Good boy," she cuddled him and walked forward.

To stand next to Dagan.

The tendril in her chest circled around her like a snake, independently poking the body of the man with its tip.

He had not been as lucky as Jakob. A dozen of the thorns were lodged deep in his body. His eyes were bloodshot, arms and legs jerking haphazardly. His chest was still moving up and down, a surprise, as most of crew had already succumbed to the affliction. There were many bodies; the reinforcements that had come down to such hopeful scenes had been mere cannon fodder.

Dagan was the last alive amongst his subjects.

"Such a pity." Mother whispered.

She began to rhythmically pull out the thorns, speaking softly as she nurtured him back to health.

"You might think I am cruel my King.

You're right. The difference is that I show it. I can't believe how you stand there, proclaiming how wonderful you are when you have been the result of so many deaths. Don't worry my dear. When I take control, the status quo will remain.

Life will be just as hard, nasty, brutish and short as it is now. It'll just be honest as well."

Dagan breathed in deeply as the last hook came out.

Mother clicked her tongue. A tendril wrapped itself around Dagan. He was brought forward to the creature.

Dagan opened his eyes. To see a yellow beak in his vision. It squawked, and finding his voice, he roared in response. The crunch and slurping sounds made Jakob look away.

All that remained was a bloodied top hat, leaning on its side.

"This, this is madness." He whispered to himself.

Mother stared at him with what seemed like surprise. It was an expression Jakob had not seen on her face before. Mother always swapped between affection or anger. Actually listening to what Jakob said was unusual.

"Why do you say that Jakob?"

Mute, he stared at the bodies surrounding them, at the blood dripping down the side of her face.

At the black, thorny tentacle that moved inside of her.

Why had he helped her?

"Because you love me." She read his mind, moving close to give him a hug.

"Because you miss your Mama. And you can only see her if you help her. Jakob my boy, you did so well! I am so proud of you. You're such a special child!"

Jakob melted into her chest. It always took him away from his worries.

He was a special boy! He deserved to be loved.

He was lost in his thoughts. Until he heard the crunching sounds of a monster cleaning up bodies. He squeezed one eye open. He saw his Mother as the beast she really was. She was no better than the *thing* mopping up human flesh.

Maybe she was worse.

Mother's arms slackened.

"Jakob?" His Mother whispered. Or tried to. It was quite difficult to form words when a gleaming dagger was occupying the space between your tongue and your tonsils.

He tried to push her away. But his arms were shaking, so her corpse just folded onto to him, her eyes staring lifelessly at Jakob.

He had never killed someone before. He had brought many people to the basement, but this was the first by his own hands. He would never have guessed that it would be Mother.

Then again, it's easier to cause the most damage to those that are closest to you.

The tendril slithered out of her. To slam into Jakob. He gasped as it burrowed into his chest. He felt it in his abdomen, moving around, a wet, slippery worm inside of him.

The blades began to move. For the second time today, he writhed around on the ground in hysterics.

Once the pain began to recede, Jakob managed to stand up. His head felt swollen. There was a presence in there.

He heard a sound in his mind. It was a different language, alien to his tongue.

But he knew what it was saying.

"Food!" It boomed.

Jakob tried to fight it. The barbs rippled around his insides in response, blood spurting out of the hole in his chest. Eventually he cried out in submission. And followed directions.

He began to move the bodies, or what was left of them, to the back of the basement. A circular hole was on the ground, brown stalagmites jutting out of the edges. He began throwing

them down the crevasse, and the pain in his head began to lessen.

But it was still there. Oh, it would be there forever.

His brain didn't feel like his. Jakob's thoughts spiralled, an echo when compared to the enormous mind of the creature.

"Food!"

He felt himself being lifted in the air and he was snapped into the hole, the creature moving back into its home.

It had plenty of food now.

The tendril slammed Jakob into a corner, and debris cracked and broke at his weight. He curled a hand around whatever he was now sitting on. It was bones. Many, many bones.

"Fresh!"

Jakob realised he would need to start making a plan quickly. There may have been a lot of corpses.

But dead bodies rot. And something was hungry.

The End

